More Misery Is Coming: Negative Concord in West Slavic

Nikola Datkova
University of Pennsylvania

Abstract. Negative Concord (NC), a phenomenon where multiple NEG-marked elements contribute to a single semantic negation, has been popularly analysed as a form of AGREE. This analysis seems plausible: AGREE as well as NC get both triggered by a Probe which looks down its domain for Goals to target. If one gives NC a closer look, though, it appears that its behaviour diverges from that of standard AGREE in multiple ways. NC constructions do not obey the typical Phase Impenetrability Condition nor Condition on Extraction Domains originally defined to restrict the powers of AGREE. Instead, NC seems to adhere to Complementiser Phrases as the main outline for its domain. These findings also entail that movement of elements targeted by NC outside its domain is more restricted compared to what the standard locality constraints. Even widely accepted types of movement, such as NEG-raising, become impossible. Therefore, if NC is an instance of AGREE, the constraints of this operation need further thorough revision. Alternatively, NC is an operation separate from AGREE and needs individual attention in literature.

Keywords: Negative Concord, Agree, Condition on Extraction Domains, Phase Impenetrability Condition, locality, movement, Neg-Raising

1 Introduction

Negative Concord, a phenomenon observed in a number of languages all around the world, requires that, whenever possible, multiple phrases forming a linguistic structure get marked for negation (NEG-marked) to convey a single unified semantic negative interpretation. In other words, merely negating a single predicate or a single phrase (as one would do, for example, in Standard English) may not be enough to create a grammatically acceptable negative construction.

Double Negation. Note that Negative Concord (NC) is a term often mistakenly used interchangeably with Double Negation (DN). While, in NC structures, every incremental NEG-marked element cooperates with the previous ones to form a single semantic (1), in DN structures, every additional NEG-marked element competes with the previous ones and changes thus the polarity of the entire sentence (2). NEG-marked elements in NC structures add up (1), whereas NEG-marked elements in DN structures cancel each other (2).

(1) Filip **ne-**vie **ni-**č o lukostreľbe.
Filip.NOM **NEG-**know.3SG **n-**thing about archery.ACC
'Filip knows nothing about archery.' *Slovak*

(2) Filip weiß **nicht nicht**-s vom Bogenschießen.
Filip.NOM know.3SG **NEG** **n-**thing about archery.ACC
'Filip doesn't know nothing about archery.'
= 'Filip knows something about archery.' *German*

Targeting. In West Slavic (WS) languages,[1] the most obvious targets of NC (i.e., words that become NEG-marked to create one consistent semantic negation) on the surface are (i) verbs (which are easily negateable by the negative preposition *ne-* (Czech, Slovak) or the negative clitic *nie* (Polish)), and (ii) *n*-expressions (words that normally convey a negative existential meaning (e.g., Laka, 1990), contribute to sentential negation, and provide a negative fragment answer to questions (Giannakidou, 2002):[2]

(3) a. Anna **ni**-koho **ne**-videla.
Anna.NOM **n-**person.ACC **NEG**-see.3SG.FEM.PAST
'Anna saw nobody.'

b. *Anna **ni**-koho videla.
Anna.NOM **n-**person.ACC see.3SG.FEM.PAST
Intended: 'Anna saw nobody.' *Slovak*

(4) a. Verča **ne**-dělá **ni-**c důležité.
Verča.NOM **NEG**-do.3SG **n-**thing.ACC important.ACC
'Verča isn't doing anything important.'

b. *Verča dělá **ni-**c důležité.
Verča.NOM do.3SG **n-**thing.ACC important.ACC
Intended: 'Verča isn't doing anything important.' *Czech*

(5) a. **Ni-**kt **nie** przyszedł.
n-person.NOM **NEG** come.3SG.PAST
'Nobody came.'

[1] West Slavic in the context of this paper covers predominantly standard Czech, Slovak, Polish, and branching dialects.

[2] Penka, 2007 offers a neat example overview of *n*-expressions from six categories (namely: person, thing, determiner, time, place, and conjunction) which may form the basis for these questions. The work also provides a worthwhile argument against analysing *n*-expressions as negative quantifiers (as originally suggested by Laka 1990). Nonetheless, the differences between these two views on *n*-expressions are negligible for the purposes of this paper.

b. *__Ni-__kt przyszedł.
__n-__person come.3SG.PAST
Intended: 'Nobody came.' *Polish*

The contrast in examples (3)-(5) is caused by the absence of NEG-marker on the verbs in examples (b). Their ungrammaticality reveals that *n*-expressions in WS may not be self-standing and require the presence of at least one verbal NEG-marker, which is generally considered to be the trigger of NC. Crucially, *n*-expressions preceding the trigger still need a NEG-marked verb (5). This classifies WS as strict NC languages (e.g., Dočekal 2020) by the following definition (e.g., Giannakidou and Zeijlstra, 2017):

(6) Strict and Non-Strict NC:
   a. *Strict NC:* The [*n*-expression] always requires the presence of the negative marker, regardless of position in the sentence.
   b. *Non-Strict NC:* The [*n*-expression] can appear without the negative marker in preverbal position or when construed with another preverbal [*n*-expression] .

Agree. Both types of NC found across a number of languages have been commonly analysed as a form of AGREE (e.g., Zeijlstra, 2004; Deal 2022), a syntactic operation between a Probe and a Goal, where Probe is a grammatical element that seeks to match its features with those of a compatible element, known as Goal, within the structure. By the original definition of AGREE, the following conditions that must be met in order for AGREE to apply successfully (Chomsky 2000):

(7) Conditions on AGREE:
   a. Probe and Goal match (they carry corresponding features)
   b. Goal is active (its feature hasn't yet been satisfied)
   c. Goal is in the domain of Probe (Probe *c*-commands Goal)
   d. Goal is the closest element (bearing a feature of interest) to Probe

This paper operates under the assumption that, in the context of NC, the Probe of AGREE is the head of the Negative Phrase (NegP), the verbal NEG-marker *ne-* (Czech and Slovak) or *nie* (Polish), and that thes Goals are all accessible *n*-expressions. Thus every time the verbal NEG-marker appears in a sentence, every *n*-expression within its domain must also bear a matching NEG-marking element *ni-*. Note that Probe's demand is insatiable (its search for compatible expressions does not stop after finding one occurrence) (e.g., Deal 2022):

(8) __Ni-__kto __ni-__kdy __ni-__komu __ni-__č __ne-__povedal.
__n-__person.NOM __n-__time __n-__person.DAT __n-__thing.ACC __NEG-__say.3SG.PAST
'Nobody ever told anything to anyone.' *Slovak*

Phases. Ever since it was first described, AGREE has been believed to be only possible within the same phase (Chomsky 2000). This means that potential Goals inside the complements of phasal heads may only AGREE with Probe until the next phasal head is merged. Phasal heads are usually considered to be heads of Complementiser Phrases (CPs), Determiner Phrases (DPs), *voice* Phrases (*v*Ps), and often also Prepositional Phrases (PPs) (e.g., Abels, 2003). This restricts the domain of Probe only to relatively nearby Goals.

Sensitivity to phases also makes AGREE subject to Phase Impenetrability Condition (PIC). PIC, as a constraint, prevents syntactic operations from accessing or affecting constituents within a phase once it is completed. In other words, once a new phase head is merged and the previous phase is thus complete, the internal structure of this phase is inaccessible for any operations from outside the phase and must remain intact. As the analysis in this paper shows, however, NC does not always obey this condition.

Locality. In addition to its sensitivity to phases, AGREE is a local operation subject to the traditional locality constraints. If two elements AGREE (which, in the case of NC, can be observed in the negative morphology on both the verb and *n*-expressions), then they

must have been based-generated locally and the movement out of their original positions is thus restricted (though not impossible). These constraints make clear predictions on the acceptability of complex sentences.

One such condition is the Condition on Extraction Domains (CED) (Huang, 1982). CED restricts the interaction with elements inside specifiers and adjuncts of certain islands (though not necessarily with the islands per se), such as subjects and adjuncts, even if they are in the same phase. This predicts that any elements bar the complement of a subject and an adjunct should be inaccessible for these syntactic operations. The analysis will show, however, that this is not the case for NC, either.

Proposal. NC clearly demonstrates characteristics of the traditional AGREE in its original definition (Chomsky, 2000): the negative Probe, usually a verbal NEG-marker, searches its domain for Goals, *n*-expressions, to NEG-mark. However, there are also noticeable differences. Namely, NC (i) ignores certain phase heads identified as impenetrable by PIC (and impacts thus a larger scope), (ii) accesses all elements inside certain islands (not just their complements), and (iii) fails to fulfil predictions on movement posed by locality constraints.

This paper proposes that while the mechanism of NC may be similar to that of AGREE, its behaviour does not fall under AGREE's original definition. Therefore, two possibilities come up: either NC is not a form of AGREE but rather a separate syntactic operation following its own defined set of rules, or NC is a form of AGREE as its mechanism suggests, in which case, however, the fundamental definition of AGREE (especially the parts tied to its phasal nature and locality) need further revision.

Structure. This paper is structured as follows: first, the analysis shows that, unlike AGREE, NC fails to obey the expectations set by PIC for PPs and DPs as well as CED for subjects and adjuncts. Second, the paper presents data that suggests that NC does, in fact, respect finite (though not infinitive) CPs as its domain and proceeds to show the consequences of this fact on the movement-related predictions made by the NEG-raising hypothesis proposed by other literature in the field.

2 Analysis

The evidence of AGREE usually comes from the analysis of their morpho-syntactic features. Typical AGREE in WS manifests on the surface by compatible morphology for person, gender, number, and case (9). When analysing NC, it is instead important to notice the cohesiveness of verbal negative morphology (i.e., the presence of *ne-* (Czech, Slovak) or *nie* (Polish)) and licensing of *n*-expressions. Should NC be an instance of AGREE, a NEG-marked verb must license all *n*-expressions in its scope (8) and only *n*-expressions in its scope.

(9) Júlia často je domáce klobásy.
Julie.NOM often eat.3SG home-made.FEM.PL.ACC sausage(FEM).PL.ACC
'Julie often eats home-made sausages.' *Slovak*

2.1 Phase Impenetrability Condition Failure

2.1.1 Prepositional Phrases Permeability

This section aims to support the claim that the domain of NC reaches beyond the one expected of the traditional AGREE. In most languages, the head of PP is phasal and thus its complement cannot be accessed by a Probe from outside the phase (e.g., Perminger, 2014). On the other hand, any element inside PPs is a perfectly valid Goal of NC for both most prominent categories of PPs: (i) argument PPs (required by the verb), and (ii) adjunct PPs (optional elaboration on the verb).

Argument PPs. WS is a group of case-rich languages (formally seven cases each, six in common use) and many instances of traditional PPs are expressed merely by a case marker with no preposition (10). Despite this bothersome circumstance, it is possible to find verbs

that do obligatorily select PPs (11, 12). While AGREE may take place inside PPs, expressions inside PPs never AGREE with those outside (11, 12). This is the correct result given the prediction derived from PIC.

(10) Dałem książkę Marii.
give.1SG.PAST book.ACC Mary.DAT
'I gave a book to Mary.' *Polish*

(11) Viktor sa spolieha *(na) svoje dobré známky.
Viktor SE rely.3SG *(on) POSS.FEM.PL.ACC good.FEM.PL.ACC grade(FEM).PL.ACC
'Viktor relies on his good grades.' *Slovak*

(12) Tamara vychádzí *(se) každým dobrým člověkem.
Tamara get.along.3SG *(with) every.MASC.INS good.MASC.INS human(MASC).INS
'Tamara gets along with every good man.' *Czech*

Suppose that these sentences, which involve typically impermeable PPs (11, 12), now merge with a negative Probe. The expectation under the traditional definition of AGREE is that every n-expression in the (simple) clause with the exception of PPs will be licensed. However, in NC constructions, any n-expression inside the PP must also be licensed for the clause to be grammatical (13), including scenarios with more than one n-expressions in the clause (14).

(13) a. *Viktor sa na niekoho **ne-**spolieha.
Viktor SE on somebody.ACC **NEG-**rely.3SG
Intended: 'Viktor doesn't rely on anybody.'

b. Viktor sa na **ni-**koho **ne-**spolieha.
Viktor SE on **n-**person.ACC **NEG-**rely.3SG
'Viktor doesn't rely on anybody.' *Slovak*

(14) a. ***Ni-**kdo s někým **ne-**vychází.
n-person with somebody.INS **NEG-**get.along.3SG
Intended: 'Nobody gets along with anyone.'

b. **Ni-**kdo s **ni-**kým **ne-**vychází.
n-person with **n-**person.INS **NEG-**get.along.3SG
'Nobody gets along with anyone.' *Czech*

Adjunct PPs. Surprisingly enough, the Probe proceeds to license n-expression Goals inside PPs even if the PPs are adjuncts rather than arguments (i.e., even if they are not obligatorily selected by the verb but rather optionally added to the clause) (15). This extends to instances of PPs which are known to be particularly difficult to access, such as causal (16) or locative PPs (17). Exactly as in the previous cases, NEG-marking inside these PPs is obligatory, which entails that the Probe can reach inside the phasal head's complement.

(15) a. *Študenti **ne-**spali počas niektorej prezentácie.
student.PL.NOM **NEG-**sleep.3PL.PAST during some. somebody.INS
Intended: 'Students didn't sleep during any of the presentations.'

b. Študenti **ne-**spali počas **ni**-ktorej prezentácie.
student.PL.NOM **NEG-**sleep.3PL.PAST during **n-**some. somebody.INS
'Students didn't sleep during any of the presentations.' *Slovak*

(16) a. ***Ne-**sedel som za niekým.
NEG-sit.3SG.PAST AUX behind somebody.INS
Intended: 'I wasn't sitting behind anybody.'

b. **Ne-**sedel som za **ni-**kým.
NEG-sit.3SG.PAST AUX behind **n-**person.INS
'I wasn't sitting behind anybody.' *Slovak*

(17) a. ***Ne-**oblečiem si ten oblek kvôli niekomu.
NEG-dress.1SG.FUT REFL DET.MASC suit.ACC because.of somebody.DAT
Intended: 'I won't wear that suit because of anyone.'

b. **Ne-**oblečiem si ten oblek kvôli **ni-**komu.
NEG-dress.1SG.FUT REFL DET.MASC suit.ACC because.of **n-**person.DAT
'I won't wear that suit because of anyone.' *Slovak*

(18) a. ***Ne-**našiel jej cennosti v nejakej zásuvke.
NEG-find.3SG.PAST her valuables.PL.ACC in some.LOC drawer.LOC.
Intended: 'He didn't find her valuable in any drawer.'

b. **Ne-**našiel jej cennosti v **ni-**jakej zásuvke.
NEG-find.3SG.PAST her valuables.PL.ACC in **n-**some.LOC drawer.LOC.
'He didn't find her valuables in any drawer.' *Slovak*

In examples (13)-(17), the verbal NEG-marker, which functions as a Probe of NC, is located just above the vP and the n-expression is inside an argument (13, 14) or adjunct (15, 16, 17) PP. Given that both vP and PP are phasal, PIC makes the prediction that any Probes outside the PPs should not be able to access these PPs' complements. However, one can observe that examples (a) which adhere to this proposal are ungrammatical. Instead, the negative Probe triggers agreement with n-expressions inside these PPs as well.

Assuming that the head of PP is a phase head, these findings suggest that the scope of NC reaches beyond its local phase. In other words, while n-expressions inside PPs are expected to be invisible to AGREE due to its phasal nature, they seem to be perfectly valid Goals for NC. This opens up the possibilities introduced earlier in the paper: either NC is not a form of AGREE, or the traditional definition of AGREE, which cannot be divorced from phases, needs further revision.

2.1.2 Determiner Phrases Permeability

Academia has an ongoing debate over the existence of DPs in languages that lack determiners on the surface, such as WS (e.g., Salzmann, 2020). This paper works under the assumption that WS has DPs and that their head is phasal. The results would, however, not be affected if the languages had NPs with a phasal head, instead (e.g., Bošković, 2014). This section demonstrates that the argument for PIC violation previously shown in the case of phasal PPs also extends to DPs in NC constructions.

Embedded DPs. In WS, genitives may complement nouns inside DPs. This entails that if such (phasal) DP is merged as an object of a (phasal) vP, this DP becomes a completed phase and its complement becomes inaccessible for operations from outside this phase. This, however, does not hold in NC constructions (19). The genitive-marked complement of the accusative-marked object in WS is separated from the NC Probe, merged just above the vP, by two phasal heads (v and D), yet must be a Goal.

(19) a. Júlia **ne-**opáčila [kúsok [**ni-**jakého syra]].
Julie.NOM **NEG-**taste.3SG bit.ACC **n-**some.GEN cheese.GEN
'Julie didn't try a piece of any cheese.'

b. *Júlia **ne-**opáčila [kúsok [nejakého syra]].
Julie.NOM **NEG-**taste.3SG bit.ACC some.GEN cheese.GEN
Intended: 'Julie didn't try a piece of any cheese.' *Slovak*

Embedded Adjuncts. A similar situation is created when, instead of a complementing

PP, the DP has an embedded adjunct PP. Once the vP is merged, this PP will be separated from the NC Probe by two phasal heads (i.e., v and D). Having said that, PIC predicts that any n-expression inside this PP should thus not be licensed by the Probe. However, these embedded adjuncts turn out to be a valid Goal of NC and yield ungrammatical results if left out (20).[3]

(20) a. Videl som [darček [pre Júliu]].
see.1SG.PAST AUX present.ACC for Julie.ACC
'I saw a present for Julie.'

b. **Ne-**videl som [darček [pre **ni-**koho]].
NEG-see.1SG.PAST AUX present.ACC for **n-**person.ACC
'I didn't see a present for anybody.'

c. ***Ne-**videl som [darček [pre niekoho]].
NEG-see.1SG.PAST AUX present.ACC for somebody.ACC
Intended: 'I didn't see a present for anybody.' *Slovak*

This data shows that elements inside the complements of DP need to be accessible to the Probe. However, if DPs have phasal heads, then their complements must not be visible to operations from outside their phase–which has not proven to be the case in NC constructions. The violation of PIC that is demonstrated by this data contributes to the proposal of this paper: that NC is either not a form of the typical AGREE, which unquestionably respects the phasal structure, or that the phasal structure per se needs further attention.

2.2 Condition on Extraction Domains Failure

Recall that CED restricts the interaction with elements (amongst others) inside subjects and adjuncts. More specifically, no individual element from within subjects and adjuncts may be separately accessible for external operations. This section demonstrates that NC constructions fail to fulfil this prediction posed by CED. To the contrary, the negative Probe is able to access and license individual n-expressions inside both subjects and adjuncts of constructions.

Subject Condition. In order to assess the ability of the negative Probe to access elements inside the subject, it is important to look at examples with more complex subjects, such as possessives (21) or clausal subjects (22), that include n-expressions in need of licensing from the negative Probe. CED predicts that these n-expressions should be inaccessible and yield an ungrammatical result. However, NC constructions do show licensing of n-expressions in subject-internal positions as well (21).

(21) a. [**Ni-**čí/**ni-**koho [otec]] **ne-**pil víno.
n-POSS.NOM father.NOM **NEG-**drink.3SG.PAST wine.ACC
'Nobody's father drank wine.'

b. *[Niečí/niekoho [otec]] **ne-**pil víno.
somebody.POSS.NOM father **NEG-**drink.3SG.PAST wine.ACC
Intended: 'Nobody's father drank wine.' *Slovak*

(22) a. Dnes **nie** je jednoduché [**ni-**koho vystopovať].
Today **NEG** be.3SG easy.3SG **n-**person.ACC track.down.INF
'It's not easy to track down anyone these days.'

b. ?[**Ni-**koho vystopovať] dnes **nie** je jednoduché.
n-person.ACC track.down.INF today **NEG** be.3SG easy.3SG
'It's not easy to track down anyone these days.'

[3] Note that if DP was not phasal, this argument would no longer hold, as the PP adjunct would be free to interact with the Probe above the freshly merged vP as it would now be at the edge of its phase.

c. ?[Vystopovať **ni-**koho] dnes **nie** je jednoduché.
track.down.INF **n-**person.ACC today **NEG** be.3SG easy.3SG
'It's not easy to track down anyone these days.' *Slovak*

Likewise, some speakers allow the licensing of clausal subjects (22), which CED predicts to be impossible, as the *n*-expression is embedded inside the subject.[4] Both of these examples also show an interesting phenomenon: that *n*-expressions may occur well before the negative Probe in the surface representation. This suggests that rather than surface-level *c*-command (e.g., Moritz and Valois, 1994), NC requires that the negative Probe *c*-commands its Goal, the *n*-expression, at least at some point of the derivation.

Adjunct Condition. This argument extends to adjuncts, too. It is no surprise that verbal complements are accessible to the negative Probe (23a). However, CED predicts that any adjuncts inside these complements should be invisible to external operations. That does not appear to be the case with NC. All *n*-expressions inside the clause, including those embedded inside verbal complements must be licensed (23b), else the construction is ungrammatical (23c).

(23) a. Júlia **ne-**chce [**ni-**komu pomôcť].
Julie.NOM **NEG-**want.3SG **n-**person.ACC help.INF
'Julie doesn't want to help anybody.'

b. Júlia **ne-**chce [prísť [**ni-**komu pomôcť]].
Julie.NOM **NEG-**want.3SG come.INF **n-**person.DAT help.INF
'Julie doesn't want to come to help anyone.'

c. *Júlia **ne-**chce [prísť [niekomu pomôcť]].
Intended: 'Julie doesn't want to come to help anyone.' *Slovak*

AGREE, in its original definition, is subject to CED, which predicts that elements inside certain islands will be inaccessible to this operation. However, as demonstrated with examples that include *n*-expressions embedded inside subjects and adjuncts, this does not appear to be a reliable restriction for NC. This, again, contributes to the proposal that either NC is not a form of AGREE or the definition of AGREE, which is inherently tied to CED, needs further revision.

2.3 A Reliable Scope: Complementiser Phrases

The previous two sections suggested that, unlike AGREE, NC ignores phases and licenses all *n*-expressions in its scope (i.e., including those inside DP and PP shells). An obvious question arises: if perhaps NC could be a version of AGREE that simply ignores phases. However, this claim would be inconsistent with its behaviour in relation to CPs. This section aims to demonstrate that despite its previous indifference towards the phases formed by DPs and PPs, NC shows sensitivity to CP boundaries (and distinguishes between their types).

Finite CPs. Finite CPs (i.e., CPs that usually contain a finite verb together with the tense, agreement, and other meaningful features) do indeed constitute phase boundaries. Whenever a new CP, a new phase head, is merged, lower phases (such as embedded CPs) become invisible to the operation. This means that every embedded CP can contain its own NC. In other words, if the negative Probe gets merged in a particular CP, every *n*-expression inside (24a) but no expression outside (24b) this CP will be licensed.

(24) a. **Ni-**komu sa **ne-**páči [že deti stále niečo
n-person.DAT SE **NEG-**like.3SG C child.PL always something.ACC
vymýšľajú].
invent.3PL

[4] Note that WS is a group of frequently scrambling languages. Therefore, *nikoho vystopovať* and *vystopovať nikoho* in (20b) and (20c) respectively might be a result of A' rather than A movement (i.e., scrambling of an object rather than moving the CP to the subject position). However, this is just an additional example of CED violation which has been already demonstrated by (21) with a firm judgement.

'Nobody likes that children are constantly cooking something up.'

b. ***Ni-**komu sa **ne-**páči [že deti stále **ni-**č vymýšľajú].
n-person.DAT SE **NEG-**like.3SG C child.PL always **n-**thing.ACC invent.3PL
Intended: 'Nobody likes that children are constantly cooking something up.'

c. #**Ni-**komu sa **ne-**páči [že deti **ni-**kdy **ni-**č
n-person.DAT SE **NEG-**like.3SG C child.PL **n-**time **n-**thing.ACC
ne-vymýšľajú].
NEG-invent.3PL
Intended: 'Nobody likes that children are constantly cooking something up.'
Actual: 'Nobody likes that children are never cooking anything up.' *Slovak*

Note that (24b) is ungrammatical because it attempts to use an unlicensed *n*-expression inside an embedded CP. In order for this example to be grammatical, the *n*-expression would have to be licensed by a negative Probe merged inside the very same CP (24c). This construction, while grammatically correct, contains two separate negative Probes and thus two separate NC structures, which no longer contribute to the same semantic negation but rather compete and create thus a DN reading.

Infinitive CPs. Infinitive CPs (i.e., CPs that contain an infinitive verb and usually lack any tense or agreement features), on the other hand, require the negative Probe from the matrix clause to license embedded *n*-expressions (26).[5] (Note that the embedded (infinitive) verb needs not be NEG-marked. Recall that the verbal NEG-marker comes with a separate NC structure and a separate semantic negation which would compete, rather than contribute to, the negation established in the matrix CP.)[6]

(26) a. **Ni-**komu sa **ne-**chce [**ni-**č robiť].
n-person.DAT SE **NEG-**want.3SG **n-**thing.ACC do.INF
'Nobody wants to do anything.'

b. ***Ni-**komu sa **ne-**chce [niečo robiť].
n-person.DAT SE **NEG-**want.3SG something.ACC do.INF
Intended: 'Nobody wants to do anything.' *Slovak*

NC's sensitivity to the finiteness status of CPs is related to the ongoing debate about the structure of infinitive CPs and has two plausible explanations: (i) infinitive, unlike finite, CPs have no C-heads (and hence no phasal head, which makes the CP-internal *n*-expressions a part of the same phase as the negative Probe and explains their licensing), or (ii) CPs do have C-heads but these heads are not phasal (which, again, allows access of the negative

[5] Note that the fact that there is only a single NEG-marked verb (but potentially multiple *n*-expressions) form each semantic negation contributes to the claim from the beginning of this paper: that the Probe of NC is the verbal NEG-marker and the Goals of NC are any complementary *n*-expressions (rather than vice versa or else).

[6] A careful reader may ask if it is at all possible to NEG-mark the embedded verb instead. This alternative is, in WS, available (though usually only chosen in particular pragmatic situations). Interestingly enough, however, even though the *n*-expression inside the embedded CP may be licensed by the matrix Probe, if the speaker chooses to NEG-mark the embedded verb instead, the embedded *n*-expression again becomes a required Goal:

(25) a. **Ni-**kto **ne-**chce [**ni-**č piť].
n-person.NOM **NEG-**want.3SG **n-**thing.ACC drink.INF
'Nobody wants to drink anything.'

b. Všetci chcú [**ni-**č **ne-**piť].
All.NOM want.3PL **n-**thing.ACC **NEG-**drink.INF
'Everybody wants to drink nothing.'

c. *Všetci chcú [niečo **ne-**piť].
All.NOM want.3PL something.ACC **NEG-**drink.INF
Intended: 'Everybody wants to drink nothing.' *Slovak*

Probe to any Goals inside this CP).

Neither case, however, contradicts the previous proposal of CPs being a reliable predictor of the NC domain. As the above examples demonstrated, every finite CP comes with its own private potential to merge a negative Probe and trigger thus NC in its entire domain. Elements inside any CP become inaccessible to negative Probes from outside this CP, similar to the prediction made by PIC. Unfortunately for the AGREE analysis of NC, however, (finite) CPs seem to be the only phases that the negative Probe respects.

2.3.1 Consequences

The previous sections suggested that while, unlike AGREE, NC ignores Ps and Ds as phase heads, it respects, similar to AGREE, finite Cs. However, not even the fact that the whole range of elements inside any finite CP is a domain to the negative Probe is entirely parallel to the AGREE analysis. The expectation is that elements that undergo AGREE inside their phase are free to move under the standard locality constraints. This section will demonstrate that elements undergoing NC are not.

Negative Polarity Items. Given the strict nature of NC in WS which demands that every *n*-expression comes accompanied by a NEG-marked verb, effectively all *n*-expressions in the language function as strong Negative Polarity Items (NPIs) (Giannakidou, 1997), elements sensitive to the presence of a negative trigger (i.e., a NEG-marked verb) and yield ungrammaticality if this trigger is absent at all points of the derivation. WS *n*-expressions are thus also crucial for tracing the movement of NEG-marked verbs.

NEG-Raising. (Interclausal) NEG-raising is a phenomenon where negation shifts its position from an embedded clause to the matrix clause and results in an identical or sufficiently similar semantic interpretation (27) (Collins and Postal, 2017). That this is a movement rather than a choice between two separate base positions for merging negation can be shown thanks to strong NPIs which need to be obligatorily licensed by a negation (28) inside the same clause.

Had the negation been generated in the matrix clause (28b), stranded NPIs in the embedded clause (28a) would entail ungrammatical results. Instead, the negation is base-generated in the embedded clause, where it subsequently licenses all clause-internal NPIs, and then optionally (in English preferably) raises to the matrix clause. This also means that, semantically as well as syntactically, the negation in (27b) is the very same negation as the one in (27a), yielding identical meanings for both sentences.

(27) a. I think [CP that Emily did**n't** get a good grade].

b. I do**n't** think [CP that Emily got a good grade].

(28) a. Everybody thinks [CP that Emily does**n't** know **jackshit** about linguistics].

b. **No**body thinks [CP that Emily knows **jackshit** about linguistics].

Parallel constructions in WS may also display negation in their embedded as well as matrix clauses (26). This creates an image of NEG-raising, which is, however, false. It can be shown that this is not the same instance of negation, as the matrix negation is never able to license embedded strong NPIs (27b). The only way to realise a negation in the matrix clause, as well as a strong NPI in the embedded one, is to NEG-mark the embedded verb (to license the NPI). This, however, yields a DN reading (27c).

(29) a. Myslím, [že Peter **ne-**príde].
think.1SG C Peter.NOM **NEG-**come.3SG.FUT
'I think Peter won't come.'

b. **Ne-**myslím, [že Peter príde].
NEG-think.1SG C Peter.NOM come.3SG.FUT

'I don't think Peter will come.' *Slovak*

(30) a. Myslím si, [že Peter **ne-**vie a-**ni** **hovno**].
think.1SG SE C Peter.NOM **NEG-**know.3SG either-**n** **shit**.ACC
'I think Peter doesn't know shit.'

b. ***Ne-**yslím si, [že Peter vie a-**ni** **hovno**].
NEG-think.1SG SE C Peter.NOM know.3SG either-**n** **shit**.ACC
Intended: 'I don't think Peter knows shit.'

c. **Ne-**yslím si, že [Peter **ne-**vie a-**ni** **hovno**].
NEG-think.1SG SE C Peter.NOM **NEG-**know.3SG either-**n** **shit**.ACC
Intended: 'I don't think Peter knows shit.'
Actual: 'I don't think Peter doesn't know shit.' *Slovak*

Recall that by the definition of strict NC languages such as WS, any n-expression in the language should face a similar fate as strong NPIs. Therefore, any analysis of negation that uses strong NPIs (e.g., Collins and Postal, 2017) can be reproduced using simply regular n-expressions in WS. In order for the n-expression to be licensed, the embedded clause needs its private negation (in addition to the already existing negation in the matrix clause), which again yields DN meaning only.[7]

(32) a. **M**yslím si, [že si **ne-**prajem **ni-**koho vidieť].
NEG-think.1SG SE C SE **NEG-**wish.1SG **n-**person.ACC see.INF
'I think I don't wish to see anyone.'

b. ***Ne-**myslím si, [že si prajem **ni-**koho vidieť].
NEG-think.1SG SE C SE wish.1SG **n-**person.ACC see.INF
'I don't think I wish to see anyone.'

c. **Ne-**myslím si, [že si **ne-**prajem **ni-**koho vidieť].
NEG-think.1SG SE C SE **NEG-**wish.1SG **n-**person.ACC see.INF
'I don't think I don't wish to see anyone.' *Slovak*

This data shows three noteworthy things. First, due to the fact that NC adheres to the CP structures, NEG-raising in WS simply does not exist, as any attempted movement outside CPs results in ungrammaticality. Second, because negation is still possible in both the matrix and embedded clauses, these must be two separate syntactic positions for generating negation. Therefore, the matrix negation in WS is syntactically different from the matrix negation in, for instance, English, although they look alike on the surface.

Last but not least, so long as there are no locality constraints preventing the movement, elements that underwent AGREE as it is traditionally defined should be free to move out of their position. However, the negative Probe is clearly not free to move, although there is no specific locality constraint preventing it. This suggests that NC not only respects its local CP as its domain, but it also locks the targetted elements inside of it. This is not a

[7] Notice that every time the clause gets embedded in a larger matrix clause containing a new negation, this negation will compete against any already established negations. For example, if two negations yield DN (semantically positive) meaning (28a), an additional matrix negation will form negative semantics again (28b).

(31) a. **Ne-**myslím si, [že tam nič **ne-nájdeme**].
NEG-think.1SG SE C there **n-**thing.ACC **NEG-**find.3PL.FUT
'I don't think we won't find anything there.'

b. **Ne-**verí, [že si nemyslím, že tam nič nenájdeme].
NEG-believe.3SG C SE **NEG-**think.1SG C there **n-**thing.ACC **NEG-**find.3PL.FUT
'(They) don't believe that I don't think that we won't find anything there.' *Slovak*

behaviour expected from AGREE.

3 Conclusions

This paper has demonstrated that NC in WS does not behave quite like AGREE as originally defined. Namely, the negative Probe of NC ignores the phasal heads of PPs and DPs, targets Goals inside their complements, and violates thus PIC. Furthermore, the Probe also targets individual elements inside subjects and adjuncts, by which it violates CED. Finally, elements undergoing NC may not move outside their CP under the regular locality constraints, as demonstrated by the absence of NEG-raising in these languages.

Nevertheless, NC also showed behaviour parallel to that of AGREE. It displayed the Probe-Goal dynamics of this operation, where the insatiable Probe targets everything inside its presumably well-defined scope (e.g., Deal, 2022). Data in this paper suggested that these scopes might be outlined by finite CPs rather than the traditional phases of AGREE. Any attempts to license n-expressions outside a particular NEG-marked CP result in either ungrammaticality or exclusively DN readings.

These findings suggest that if NC is to be a form of AGREE, then AGREE's traditional definition is defective. Some literature that revises the locality and motivation of AGREE has been presented (e.g., Bošković, 2007) which could explain the current failures of PIC but, if NC is to be an AGREE-like operation, more light needs to be shed on the failures of CED as well as the real conditions of (especially A') movement under this type of operation. On these fronts, NC is incompatible with the expectations posed by the definition of AGREE.

Alternatively, if no better conditions are found to regulate the impact of AGREE its behaviour necessarily conflicts that of NC, then NC may instead need to be analysed as its own operation, separate from AGREE. However, this option raises additional questions: issues such as NC's proven Probe-Goal interface (which is suspiciously similar to that of AGREE) as well as its sensitivity to finite and infinitive CPs (which corresponds to their phasal status, tightly associated with AGREE) would need to be further explained.

References

Abels, K. (2003). Successive cyclicity, anti-locality, and adposition stranding. *ETD Collection for University of Connecticut.*

Bošković, (2007). On the locality and motivation of move and agree: An even more minimal theory. *Linguistic Inquiry*, 38(4):589–644.

Bošković, (2014). Now i'm a phase, now i'm not a phase: On the variability of phases with extraction and ellipsis. *Linguistic Inquiry*, 45:27–89.

Chomsky, N. (2000). New horizons in the study of language and mind. *Cambridge University Press.*

Collins, C. and Postal, P. (2017). Interclausal neg raising and the scope of negation. *Glossa a Journal of General Linguistics*, 2(1).

Deal, A. R. (2022). Negative concord as downward agree.

Dočekal, M. (2020). *Advances in formal Slavic linguistics 2017*, chapter N-words and NPIs: Between syntax, semantics, and experiments, pages 15–49. Language Science Press, Berlin.

Giannakidou, A. (1997). The landscape of polarity items.

Giannakidou, A. (2002). N-words and negative concord.

Giannakidou, A. and Zeijlstra, H. (2017). *The Landscape of Negative Dependencies: Negative Concord and N-Words*, pages 1–38.

Huang, C.-T. (1982). *Logic Relations in Chinese and the Theory of Grammar.* PhD thesis, MIT.

Laka, I. (1990). *Negation in syntax on the nature of functional categories and projections.* PhD thesis, Department of Linguistics and Philosophy, Massachusetts Institute of Technology.

Moritz, L. and Valois, D. (1994). Pied-piping and specifier-head agreement. *Linguistic Inquiry*, 25(4):667–707.

Penka, D. (2007). A crosslinguistic perspective on n-words. *Anuario del Seminario de Filología Vasca "Julio de Urquijo"*, 41.

Perminger, O. (2014). *Agreement and Its Failures.* The MIT Press.

Salzmann, M. (2020). The np vs. dp debate. why previous arguments are inconclusive and what a good argument could look like. evidence from agreement with hybrid nouns. *Glossa: a journal of general linguistics*, 5.